

SESSION ONE: THE SILENT ROAD

The Qilvayas Symphony

An adventure for 4–6 characters of 3rd level – the final field exercise, and the night everything changes

OVERVIEW

The party's final field exercise: a provincial magistrate in the river town of Dravenna, in the loyalist eastern march called the Ostmark (see the sourcebook's Atlas), has requested academy assistance with a string of caravan disappearances on the Ostmark trade road. The season is Harvestide — early autumn, the tail of the Academy's traditional Hay–Harvestide exercise window, with the Suthmark's harvest festival underway far to the south and the eastern roads in their last good weeks before Vinmoon turns them to mud. The culprits are deserters from a provincial legion — oath-breakers, in the campaign's most literal sense — holed up in a ruined watch-fort and increasingly desperate. The party investigates, tracks them down, and resolves the situation by steel or by parley. That night, celebrating a job well done, they receive the shared vision that changes everything.

Designed for a five-hour session. Suggested pacing budget: Dravenna and the briefing (45 minutes); the ambush site and Yanna (60 minutes); the trail and the scout picket (30 minutes); Redwatch, by whatever approach (90 minutes); resolution and the celebration at the Gilded Ford (45 minutes); the Vision (30 minutes, unhurried). At this length both the looter encounter and the scout picket are standard content, not optional. If the table runs long anyway, the celebration and Vision must not be cut — compress the road instead.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

Eight soldiers of the Third Provincial Legion deserted four months ago after their commander, Colonel Aurel Dessen, sold off the garrison's winter grain and blamed the shortfall on them. Led by Sergeant Varkos Dren, they fled east, turned to robbery to eat, and occupied the ruined imperial watch-fort called Redwatch. They have hit four caravans in six weeks. They have killed — twice, both times when a guard fought back — and the killings sit badly on most of them.

Here is the part the party cannot yet understand: since breaking their oaths of service, every one of them suffers the same recurring nightmare — storm clouds, a burning city they have never seen, and something vast moving behind the dark. The entity beneath the capital does not know them and has not chosen them; but broken oaths resonate with it, and the deserters have become faintly audible to something that has been listening for two thousand years. Dren, whose oath ran deepest — he defaced his own legion oath-medallion the night he fled — has it worst. He has barely slept in a month, and something of the dark has begun to bleed through him. None of this should be explained in this session. It exists so that when the party receives the same imagery in their vision hours later, the DM knows the echo is real — and so the campaign's central mechanism (betrayal feeds the shadow) is

present from the very first fight, invisible and waiting to be rediscovered much later.

SCENE 1: DRAVENNA

Dravenna announces itself by smell before sight — river mud, tar, and fish — and then by sound: the groan of the great water-wheel at the ford. It is a town of perhaps two thousand, prosperous by border standards, its stone bridge and customs house relics of a time when imperial engineers built things to last. The imperial wolf-standard still flies over the magistrate's hall, though the flag is patched and the pole leans. People here look at your academy uniforms the way farmers look at rain clouds: potentially useful, potentially trouble.

THE BRIEFING

Magistrate Cassivar Ondrei receives the party in a hall that doubles as courtroom and granary office. He is in his fifties, precise, visibly tired, and honest by the standards of provincial officials — which is to say he skims modestly and hates violence on his roads because it is bad for taxes. He lays out the facts:

Four caravans hit in six weeks on the Ostmark road, all within a day's ride east. Goods taken: food, coin, boots, medicine. Not luxuries — supplies.

Two dead across the four attacks, both caravan guards who resisted. Drivers and merchants were bound, not harmed. "Disciplined," Ondrei says, and the word clearly bothers him.

The latest attack was two days ago. One survivor unaccounted for — a teamster named Yanna, who fled into the brush and has not come into town.

Terms: 200 gp to the party for ending the attacks, plus a 25 gp bounty per bandit — payable equally for capture or proof of death. Ondrei prefers capture: "Dead men can't testify against whoever made them run." That line is deliberate — he already suspects deserters, and suspects their commander is the deeper rot.

RUMORS IN TOWN (D6, OR FEED AS DESIRED)

1. "Third Legion pay wagon never came through this spring. First time in nine years." (True; connects to the grain scandal.)
2. "The attacks are ghosts from old Redwatch. That fort's been cursed since the old wars." (False, but points at the right location.)
3. "They took a whole crate of poppy-milk off Serren's wagon. Somebody's hurt bad, or can't sleep." (True. Dren cannot sleep.)

4. “One driver swears the leader talked in his sleep by their fire — begging somebody’s pardon, over and over.” (True.)

5. “Magistrate’s cousin runs the ferry and raised his rates the week the attacks started. Convenient.” (True but unrelated — a red herring with local color.)

6. “Dogs won’t go east past the old milestone anymore. Haven’t for weeks.” (True. Animals dislike what is bleeding through Dren.)

SCENE 2: THE AMBUSH SITE

Half a day east: an overturned wagon, scattered grain gone to birds, wheel ruts, and a burned cookfire. Investigation is tiered — every character who searches learns the DC 10 information automatically on a success; higher results stack additional detail.

DC 10 (Investigation or Survival): Eight to ten attackers on foot. They took food and supplies first, strongboxes second. Tracks lead northeast into the hills.

DC 13: Boot prints are legion-issue, uniform pattern and wear — these are soldiers, or were. The ambush used proper fire discipline and a bounding withdrawal: trained, coordinated, rehearsed.

DC 15: One set of prints is wrong. The stride is even but the weight is off, as though the man is lighter than his boots — and beside the cold cookfire, one patch of ground is scorched in a shape no fire makes: a long, thin shadow of a standing man, burned into the grass.

YANNA

A successful DC 12 Wisdom (Perception) or Survival check — or simply calling out peacefully — finds the missing teamster hiding in a culvert, dehydrated and terrified but unhurt. Yanna is in her twenties, practical, ashamed of having run. She gives the party three things if treated kindly: confirmation the attackers were soldiers (“they moved like a wall, all together”); the direction of their withdrawal (toward the Redwatch hills); and, reluctantly, one more thing she has told no one, because it sounds mad:

“Their sergeant — the one giving orders. When he stood over me I looked down so he’d think me no threat. And his shadow... sir, his shadow moved after he did. Just a half-beat behind. Like it was following him, not — not attached. I’ve prayed on it every night since.”

Encounter: as the party finishes its investigation (or if it lingers past dusk), 4 Roadside Looters (6 for a party of five or six) arrive to pick over the wreck — local opportunists, not deserters. They flee at half strength. This is a warm-up fight and a tone-setter: the fractured empire produces scavengers, and not every armed stranger is the enemy the party is hunting.

SCENE 3: THE TRAIL TO REDWATCH

The trail runs a day northeast into dry hills. A DC 13 Wisdom (Survival) check follows it cleanly; failure costs hours

and arrives at dusk rather than midday (raising the value of stealth or parley over assault). En route, the party crosses a deserter picket: 2 Deserter Scouts watching the approach from a rocky rise. The scouts’ orders are to observe and report, not to fight — played well, the party can capture or bypass them; played badly, one escapes and the fort is alerted (deserters in Scene 4 cannot be surprised and begin behind their walls).

A captured scout, questioned, is scared, exhausted, and closer to relief than defiance. He confirms the numbers (eight, counting the sergeant), the layout, and — if pressed about why they look so hollow — the nightmares: “All of us. Every night. The same burning city. Ask any man in that fort. It started when we ran.” He will beg the party for mercy for the others: “Most of us just didn’t want to hang for the colonel’s theft. Dren’s the only one who’s... gone somewhere we can’t follow.”

SCENE 4: REDWATCH

Redwatch was built to watch a border that has since moved three times. What remains is a shell: a square curtain wall breached on the southern side, a gatehouse with no gate, and a single intact tower leaning against the sky like a tired sentry. Smoke rises thin from the courtyard. Somewhere inside, a man is shouting at someone — or at no one.

THE SITUATION INSIDE

Seven deserters and Sergeant Dren occupy the fort. Morale is broken: they are sleepless, frightened of their own sergeant, and most would surrender to anyone offering terms that are not a rope. Dren is another matter. He has convinced himself that the nightmares are a hunt — that something is coming for oath-breakers — and that stopping, surrendering, or sleeping means being caught. He is, in the campaign’s tragic irony, essentially correct about the first part and wrong about everything it implies. He will not surrender. He can be isolated from his men, but not saved.

THREE APPROACHES

Parley: A party that approaches openly under peace-sign or academy colors is not fired upon — the deserters want a way out. A DC 13 Charisma (Persuasion) check (advantage if the party invokes Ondrei’s capture-preference and testimony against the colonel, or if they captured a scout alive and treated him well) convinces the seven to stand down — but Dren, watching from the tower, will not have it. He attacks the parley himself, alone if he must, and any deserters not yet won over (on a failed check, all of them) fight beside him out of fear. On a successful parley, the climax becomes the party and seven grateful deserters against Dren and what comes out of him.

Stealth: The southern breach is unwatched at night (the deserters fear the dark now and cluster near fires). A DC 12 group Dexterity (Stealth) check reaches the courtyard undetected, allowing the party to isolate Dren in the tower or take sentries quietly. Each sentry removed before the alarm subtracts one deserter from the main fight.

Assault: A frontal approach means the full garrison behind walls: harder, louder, and the approach most likely to kill men who wanted to surrender. Let it be a fight; let the aftermath ask the question.

THE CLIMAX AND SCALING

Baseline (4 characters): Sergeant Varkos Dren plus 3 Oathless Deserters, arriving in two waves (deserters first, Dren from the tower on round 2). For 5 characters: add 1 deserter. For 6: add 2 deserters, and Dren's Shadow-Touched trait activates from the start of combat rather than at half hit points. If the party negotiated the garrison down, replace the deserter allies of Dren with nothing — he fights alone, and activates Shadow-Touched immediately; the drama carries the encounter.

WHEN DREN FALLS

The sergeant drops to his knees, and for one heartbeat his face is only a tired man's face — relieved, almost. Then his shadow does not fall with him. It stays standing. It turns. Where its head should be there is nothing you can name, and from somewhere beneath the world you feel more than hear a sound: low, vast, patient — the echo of the roar from a nightmare you have not yet had. The shadow tears free of the dead man like cloth ripping, and it is hungry.

The Umbral Remnant (stat block below) attacks the nearest creature. It is a fragment, not the entity — a residue that accreted in Dren over months of resonance. It fights until reduced below half hit points or struck by radiant damage, then shrieks soundlessly and dissolves into the ground, flowing toward a crack in the earth — flowing, though no player can measure this, in the precise direction of the imperial capital. Surviving deserters flee or surrender at the sight of it; to a man, they say some version of the same thing afterward: "That's it. That's what's in the dream."

THE VIGIL AT REDWATCH

Before the party leaves, there is a thing every Zhuvedian child knows and every academy graduate has been formally taught: no body goes into the ground, the water, or the stone before it has been kept through one full night's Vigil — watched, lit, never left alone — because the Matron watches the dead home, and she does it at night. It applies to deserters. It applies to oath-breakers. Doctrine is unambiguous and always has been: the Vigil is owed to the dead as dead, not as the good. A party that simply rides away from the bodies at Redwatch has done something their own training tells them is wrong, and the DM should let them feel the shape of that without lecturing — a character raised devout might simply start gathering firewood without announcing why.

If they keep it, give the Vigil ten quiet minutes and no dice: bodies laid out, a fire, a long night in a ruined fort, and the specific discomfort of watching over men they killed a few hours ago. This is the session's best opportunity for characters to say true things to one another, and it frequently lands harder than the fight did. Magistrate Ondrei, told of it afterward, thinks noticeably better of them — provincial magistrates notice who keeps the old forms when nobody is watching. (DM note: if a character carries Dren's medallion through the Vigil, it stays cold all night. Say nothing about it. Let them notice.)

Aftermath details worth narrating: Dren's body is unnaturally light, like driftwood. Around his neck the party finds his legion oath-medallion, deliberately defaced with a knife — and cold. It stays cold, always, no matter how long it is carried. It is not magical to any detection the party can

currently cast. Let a player keep it. It is the campaign's first artifact of the truth, and it will matter that someone chose to carry it.

SCENE 5: RESOLUTION

Ondrei pays promptly and in full — 200 gp plus bounties (25 gp per deserter, captured or accounted for; a full sweep of eight pays 200 gp more). If any deserters survived to testify, Ondrei is genuinely moved, and begins quiet proceedings against the Third Legion's colonel — a thread the DM can develop or leave as background texture of a system occasionally, imperfectly working. If the party mentions the shadow, Ondrei goes very still, thanks them formally, and writes none of it down. "Some reports," he says, "outlive the men who file them. Enjoy the Gilded Ford tonight, on the town."

The evening at the Gilded Ford inn should be warm and unhurried — give it real table time. The exercise is complete; graduation is weeks away; the company they named in Session Zero is almost real. Invite each player to narrate a small moment of celebration or reflection: a toast, a letter home, an argument about the company charter, a quiet look at a cold medallion. Let them be young and finished and proud. Then they go to bed.

SCENE 6: THE VISION

Run this as follows: ask each player, one at a time, what their character dreams about on a good night — let them answer in a sentence or two, unhurried. Then, whatever each answer was, continue: "And then the dream opens beneath you, like a floor giving way." Read the following once all players have answered, addressing the whole table:

You stand on a high place you have never stood, above a city you know from engravings and lecture halls: the imperial capital, seat of the Lupine Throne. It is night, and the city is burning. The flames are the color of a dying ember and they move wrongly — upward too slowly, sideways when no wind blows, clinging to stone that should not burn. You try to cry out. Nothing in you obeys. You are present the way a witness is present: permitted to see, and nothing else. Storm clouds turn above the city, vast and slow, and your gaze is dragged upward against your will — and there, behind the clouds, something moves. Not a shape. A displacement, as if the sky were cloth and something on the far side pressed against it. It is vast beyond vastness, and it is aware, and when it sounds — not a roar heard, but a roar felt, in teeth and bone and the base of the skull — you understand that it is not arriving. It has always been here. It is waking. The dark takes everything, and you wake drenched in sweat, heart hammering, with the taste of ash on your tongue.

Then go around the table one final time: each character wakes in their room at the Gilded Ford. Let the players find each other — do not prompt it — and let them discover in their own words that the vision was identical, down to the smallest details. Characters who fought the Umbral Remnant may make the connection to the sound it made; do not confirm or deny. When the unease has fully landed, end the session. Do not run the morning after. That is Session Two's opening, and this silence is the best cliffhanger the campaign will ever get for free.

STAT BLOCKS

Roadside Looter

Medium humanoid (any race), neutral

Armor Class: 12 (leather armor)

Hit Points: 11 (2d8 + 2)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
11 (+0)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

Senses: passive Perception 10

Languages: Common

Challenge: 1/8 (25 XP)

Scavenger's Nerve. The looter has disadvantage on saving throws against being frightened. It flees when reduced to half its hit points or when half its group has fallen.

ACTIONS

Club. Melee Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 3 (1d4 + 1) bludgeoning damage.

Sling. Ranged Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, range 30/120 ft., one target. Hit: 3 (1d4 + 1) bludgeoning damage.

Deserter Scout

Medium humanoid (any race), neutral

Armor Class: 13 (leather armor)

Hit Points: 16 (3d8 + 3)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
11 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	11 (+0)	13 (+1)	11 (+0)

Skills: Nature +4, Perception +5, Stealth +6, Survival +5

Senses: passive Perception 15

Languages: Common

Challenge: 1/2 (100 XP)

Keen Hearing and Sight. The scout has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on hearing or sight.

Sleepless. The scout has disadvantage on saving throws against being frightened, and against effects that would put it to sleep it instead automatically fails. (It has not truly slept in weeks; part of it wants to.)

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The scout makes two shortsword attacks or two shortbow attacks.

Shortsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d6 + 2) piercing damage.

Shortbow. Ranged Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, range 80/320 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d6 + 2) piercing damage.

Oathless Deserter

Medium humanoid (any race), neutral

Armor Class: 14 (worn chain shirt)

Hit Points: 19 (3d8 + 6)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)

Skills: Athletics +4, Perception +2

Senses: passive Perception 12

Languages: Common

Challenge: 1/2 (100 XP)

Legion Discipline. While within 5 feet of another Oathless Deserter, the deserter has a +1 bonus to AC (drilled shield-line habits die hard).

Haunted. The deserter has disadvantage on saving throws against being frightened. If it witnesses the Umbral Remnant, it must succeed on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw or drop its weapons and flee or surrender.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The deserter makes two spear attacks.

Spear. Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d6 + 2) piercing damage, or 6 (1d8 + 2) piercing damage if used with two hands to make a melee attack.

Sergeant Varkos Dren

Medium humanoid (human), neutral evil (by despair, not design)

Armor Class: 15 (studded leather, shield fragments)

Hit Points: 58 (9d8 + 18)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	11 (+0)	9 (-1)	12 (+1)

Skills: Athletics +5, Intimidation +3, Perception +1

Saving Throws: Str +5, Con +4

Senses: passive Perception 11

Languages: Common

Challenge: 3 (700 XP)

Shadow-Touched. While Dren is below half his hit point maximum (or from the start of combat, for a party of six), his weapon attacks deal an extra 3 (1d6) necrotic damage, and his shadow visibly moves a half-beat behind his body.

No Way Back. Dren has advantage on saving throws against being frightened and against any effect that would charm him into standing down. He cannot be talked into surrender — only into fighting alone.

Final Tearing. When Dren is reduced to 0 hit points, the Umbral Remnant erupts from his body in his space and rolls initiative. Dren cannot be returned to life by any means available at this tier; the body is unnaturally light.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Dren makes two longsword attacks.

Longsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 7 (1d8 + 3) slashing damage, or 8 (1d10 + 3) slashing damage if used with two hands.

Heavy Crossbow. Ranged Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, range 100/400 ft., one target. Hit: 7 (1d10 + 2) piercing damage.

REACTIONS

Parry. Dren adds 2 to his AC against one melee attack that would hit him. To do so, he must see the attacker and be wielding a melee weapon.

Umbral Remnant

Medium undead (residue), chaotic evil

Armor Class: 12

Hit Points: 16 (weakened fragment; see Dissolution)

Speed: 40 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
6 (-2)	14 (+2)	13 (+1)	6 (-2)	10 (+0)	8 (-1)

Skills: Stealth +4 (+6 in dim light or darkness)

Damage Resistances: acid, cold, fire, lightning, thunder; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Damage Vulnerabilities: radiant

Senses: darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10

Languages: —

Challenge: 1/2 (100 XP)

Amorphous. The remnant can move through a space as narrow as 1 inch wide without squeezing.

Dissolution. When the remnant is reduced below half its hit points, or the first time it takes radiant damage, it emits a soundless shriek every creature within 60 feet feels in its teeth, then dissolves into the ground and is gone. It flows, unerringly, in the direction of the imperial capital — though no character can know this yet.

ACTIONS

Umbral Touch. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 9 (2d6 + 2) necrotic damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 12 Wisdom saving throw or be frightened of the remnant until the end of its next turn.

NPC PROFILES

MAGISTRATE CASSIVAR ONDREI

Human, 50s, precise, tired, provincial-honest. Speech pattern: short declaratives, dislikes adjectives, pauses before anything that costs money. Wants his roads safe and the deserters' colonel exposed. Will remember the party — favorably or otherwise — and provincial magistrates write letters. He is a small, renewable ally if treated well, and the first entry in the party's reputation ledger.

YANNA

Human teamster, 20s, practical, ashamed of surviving by running. If the party treats her kindly, she turns up again — the campaign can use a recurring teamster who owes the party her life and hears everything on the roads. Speech pattern: hedges everything ("I don't say it was, I say it looked like") except the one thing she is certain of: the shadow moved wrong.

**OPTIONAL CONTENT
(BEYOND THE FIVE-HOUR
CORE)**

The Cellar Problem (~30 minutes): The Gilded Ford's proprietor, hearing the party are academy-trained, sheepishly asks for help with the haunted cellar — scratching in the walls, bottles knocked over, "a cold presence." It is a badger. A large, indignant badger that has tunneled in behind the wine racks and regards the cellar as conquered territory. Play the investigation absolutely straight; let paranoia bloom; let the reveal be ridiculous. Design function beyond the laugh: it teaches the table, one session before it matters, that not every strange thing is the metaplot — a calibration the campaign will quietly rely on. Reward: free lodging for life at the Gilded Ford, and a story the party will retell for years.

**DIVERGING PATHS (DM
ONLY)**

Outcomes here echo forward. Record them in the DM Reference Guide's Branch Ledger.

Deserters spared vs. killed: Survivors who testify give Ondrei a real case against Colonel Dessen — the Colonel's Reckoning hook fires with strength, and the party gains standing witnesses in the Ostmark. A full-lethality resolution guts the case: Dessen likely survives his inquiry, remains in grade, and remembers who ruined his quiet arrangement. Either way he learns the party's names.

Parley vs. assault at Redwatch: A parley resolution seeds the party's reputation as problem-solvers rather than killers — word travels ahead of them on the roads (advantage on first-impression Persuasion with Ostmark commonfolk). An

assault reputation closes some doors and opens others: certain warlords' recruiters take notice.

Yanna's treatment: Treated kindly, she becomes a recurring road-contact and, much later, a witness whose testimony about "the sergeant's shadow" matters. Dismissed or frightened, she vanishes into the teamster circuits and the campaign loses its only civilian eyewitness to the first manifestation.

The medallion: If no player chooses to carry Dren's medallion, do not force it — but note that Vaelindra's Session Two question ("has anything cold come into your possession?") lands differently, and the Session Three and Six cold-resonance beats need an alternate carrier (Ondrei forwards it to the capital as evidence, where it can resurface).

district (grants advantage on navigation checks in the region); the recovered poppy-milk crate (worth 40 gp to an apothecary, or goodwill if returned to its owner). XP for tables using it: roughly 1,450–1,900 depending on encounters run — in either system, the party should remain 3rd level tonight and reach 4th early in Session Three, after the Seeress.

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"That's it. That's what's in the dream."

LOOT AND FOUND

REWARDS — SESSION ONE

— REDWATCH

Find	Value / Effect
The deserters' cache (robbed caravans)	87 gp mixed coin, 30 gp trade goods — returnable to Dravenna's merchants; returning it is worth more than keeping it (reputation, and Ondrei notices)
Legion medical stores	2 potions of healing — old stock, Church-stamped, still good
Dren's medallion	Canon — now formalized as a homebrew item (below)
Dren's legion shortsword	Mundane, masterwork-kept, unit-engraved — evidence for the Dessen case, and a soldier's effects owed to somebody

ENCOUNTER HEAT — DM AWARENESS (VALIDATION PASS)

Two flags from the mechanical audit, for awareness rather than revision: the Oathless Deserters deal 10–12 damage per round — CR 1-grade output at a CR 1/2 label — so the Redwatch climax runs hotter than its adjusted-hard budget suggests for a fresh 3rd-level table; and the Deserter Scouts are glass cannons (high damage, 16 hp) whose Pack Tactics amplify hard when they focus fire. Neither needs changing — the yield thresholds and parley paths are the pressure valves — but know the stove is on.

REWARDS AND ADVANCEMENT

Coin: 200 gp contract + up to 200 gp in bounties + 34 gp in scattered strongbox recoveries at Redwatch. Items: Dren's defaced oath-medallion (cold, nonmagical to current detection, significant later); a legion-issue map of the border